



HGM Industry Acumen Dictionary

253 hotel, resort and marketing terms, in three tiers and nine sections — the words you'll hear on a resort call and in our own reports. Each entry gives a plain definition, the formula where there is one, and a line showing how you might use it.

A CORE TERMS · 30

Taught in the session and on the check. Know what each one means, why the owner cares, and how to work the formula.

1 · Core revenue metrics

ADR (average daily rate)

Room revenue ÷ Rooms sold

Room revenue divided by rooms sold — the average price a sold room actually went for.

Your ADR held up nicely this month — the question is whether the discounting on quiet nights is pulling it down.

Ancillary revenue

Everything a guest spends beyond the room — food and beverage, spa, activities, add-ons — and the lever marketing can move without touching rate.

Rooms are only part of the story here — how much of your ancillary revenue comes from the spa and dinner?

Comp set

The set of properties an owner benchmarks against, and the basis of every index on an STR report.

Who's in your comp set? I'd like to see who you're measuring yourself against before we talk about rate.

Denial

Demand that tried to book a date and could not because it was sold out.

If you're turning people away on peak weekends, that denial is demand we can price for, not just celebrate.

Flow-through

$$\text{Change in GOP} \div \text{Change in revenue}$$

How much of each extra dollar of revenue actually reaches profit rather than being eaten by cost.

More revenue is only good news if it flows through — what's the flow-through on the extra bookings from the promotion?

NOI (net operating income)

$$\text{NOI} = \text{GOP} - \text{management fees} - \text{fixed charges}$$

GOP less management fees and fixed charges; what owners and buyers price the property on. USALI now labels this line EBITDA.

When you think about selling or expanding one day, NOI is the number the buyer will look at first.

Regret

Demand that looked at a date and left without booking, usually on price or restriction.

Lots of people are looking at those dates and leaving — that's regret, and it usually points to price or a minimum stay.

Revenue management (the function)

The job itself; at this ICP it may be the owner, a part-timer, or an outsourced firm.

Who handles revenue management for you right now — you, someone on the team, or an outside firm?

RevPAR (revenue per available room)

$$\text{Room revenue} \div \text{Rooms available} (= \text{ADR} \times \text{Occupancy})$$

Rate and fill in one number; what owners reach for when asked how the year is going.

RevPAR tells us rate and fill together, so we're not fooled by a full house sold too cheap.

2 · Rates, pricing and restrictions

Orphan night

A single night left stranded between two bookings, too short for most guests to want.

That single Tuesday between two bookings is an orphan night — a small offer could turn it into revenue.

Rate parity

A contractual commitment not to undercut an OTA's rate — Expedia or Booking.com, say — on your own site.

Does your Booking.com contract include rate parity? That decides what we can offer on your own site.

3 · Distribution and OTA economics

Metasearch

Google Hotel Ads, Tripadvisor, Trivago — rate comparison that passes traffic on to a booking channel.

Guests comparing prices on Google or Tripadvisor are on metasearch — are you showing up there with your direct rate?

4 · Demand, segments and time

Booking curve

The shape reservations accumulate in ahead of a stay date, which differs by segment.

Your booking curve shows when each type of guest books, so we can time the ads to match.

Effective OTB

$$\text{OTB} \times (1 - \text{expected cancellation rate})$$

On-the-books weighted for expected cancellation.

Once we allow for likely cancellations, your effective OTB for October is a bit lower than it looks.

Lead time

How far ahead of arrival a booking is made; it differs sharply by date class and by segment.

What's your usual lead time for summer? If guests book months out, spring is when we need to be in front of them.

Pace

How fast bookings are arriving for a future date against last year or target.

How is October pacing against last year? That tells us whether to push now or hold.

Transient vs group

Individual bookings versus contracted blocks — two different businesses inside one property.

Is most of your business transient or group? The two need very different marketing.

5 · Property types, structure and ownership

Cap rate

$\text{NOI} \div \text{Purchase price}$

The yield a buyer prices the property at, applied to NOI.

A higher NOI at the same cap rate means the property is worth more — that's the long game.

6 · Guest behaviour and reputation

First-party data

Guest data the property owns outright, which is most of why direct matters.

Every direct booking gives you first-party data — the guest's email is yours, not the OTA's.

7 · Marketing metrics and HGM's translation

Cannibalization

When an ad, promotion or channel takes bookings the resort would have gotten anyway, instead of creating new ones. The numbers look like growth, but revenue has only moved around, often at a higher cost.

Before we celebrate the promo, let's check for cannibalization — were those guests going to book anyway?

CAPI (conversions API)

Server-side event sending, which survives the browser blocking the pixel.

With CAPI connected, bookings still get reported even when a guest's browser blocks the pixel.

CPM (cost per mille — cost per thousand impressions)

$(\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Impressions}) \times 1,000$

Cost per thousand impressions — the ad number an owner is most likely to quote at you.

Your CPM went up this month, which usually means we're competing with more advertisers for the same people.

Effective commission (EC)

$\text{Total cost of winning the booking} \div \text{Gross booking value}$

The full cost of winning a booking as a percentage of its value, so a direct booking and an OTA booking compare on one line.

Once we count ad spend and discounts too, what's your effective commission on a direct booking compared with Booking.com?

Incrementality

Whether a booking actually happened because of the advertising, or would have happened anyway.

The real test is incrementality — did the ads bring in bookings that wouldn't have happened anyway?

UTM (urchin tracking module link tags)

Link tags that make traffic traceable.

We tag every link with a UTM so we can see exactly which post or email brought each booking.

8 · Tools and software, by category

CRM tools

Where guest data is held and segmented for marketing; Revinate, Cendyn.

Which CRM tool holds your guest list? We could use it to invite past guests back.

Guest messaging tools

Pre-arrival and in-stay messaging to the guest; Duve, and Whistle (now part of Cloudbeds).

Your guest messaging tool is a good place to offer upgrades before arrival.

Rate shopping and market intelligence tools

Watching comp-set rates automatically; Lighthouse, formerly OTA Insight.

A rate shopping tool would show you what the resorts around you are charging each night.

The tools map

PMS, channel manager, booking engine, dynamic pricing — what each does and which names sit where.

Which PMS, channel manager and booking engine are you on? That tells us what we can connect to.

Upsell tools

Paid upgrades before and at arrival; Oaky (part of Plusgrade since 2025).

An upsell tool can offer a room upgrade automatically a few days before check-in.

Not taught in the session, but on the check. Read these before you take it.

1 · Core revenue metrics

Boutique

A small, design-led, independently run property — the category most of this ICP puts itself in.

You've built something boutique, so the story we tell needs to feel as personal as the place.

Capture rate

The share of guests staying at the property who eat or drink at its own restaurant or bar.

$\text{Covers from in-house guests} \div \text{In-house guests}$

What's your capture rate at the restaurant? If guests are eating in town, that's revenue walking out the door.

EBITDA (earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation)

Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation — the number in a sale conversation.

$\text{GOP} - \text{management fees} - \text{fixed charges}$

If a buyer ever comes calling, EBITDA is the line they'll want to see on your P&L.

Flagged

A property operating under a chain brand, as opposed to independent or soft-branded.

Were you ever approached about being flagged, or have you always wanted to stay independent?

Occupancy %

The share of available rooms sold in a period; HGM also reads it per date, cancellation-weighted.

$\text{Rooms sold} \div \text{Rooms available}$

Occupancy is strong, but let's look at it by date — the averages hide the nights you most need to fill.

The profit ladder

The order revenue falls through on a hotel P&L, from total revenue down to NOI, and where each cost is deducted.

Let's walk down the profit ladder together so we can see where the extra revenue actually lands.

2 · Rates, pricing and restrictions

Dynamic pricing

Rates moving automatically with demand; the category Wheelhouse and PriceLabs sit in.

Are you using dynamic pricing, or setting rates by hand each season?

Overbooking

Selling past physical capacity on purpose, on the expectation that some bookings will cancel or not arrive.

Do you ever overbook to cover no-shows, or would you rather keep a room empty than walk a guest?

Package rate

Room plus something — breakfast, spa credit, an activity — sold at one price.

A package rate with breakfast and a spa credit gives people a reason to book direct instead of on an OTA.

Rack rate

The published undiscounted rate; increasingly notional, still quoted.

Hardly anyone pays the rack rate, but it's still the anchor guests compare your offers against.

Rate fence

The condition that stops a discount leaking to guests who would have paid full price — a date range, a membership, a non-refundable rule.

If we offer a midweek discount, we need a rate fence so weekend guests don't grab it too.

Rate plan

A sellable combination of rate, conditions and inclusions — the unit an owner actually loads.

How many rate plans do you have loaded? Too many can confuse guests on the booking page.

Rate shopping

Watching what the comp set is charging, usually through a tool.

Do you do any rate shopping, or do you set prices without looking at what nearby resorts charge?

Resort fee / amenity fee

A mandatory per-night charge outside the room rate.

Do you charge a resort fee? Guests notice it at checkout, so we should be upfront about it in the ads.

Soft dates

Upcoming dates where bookings are pacing below target or below last year, signalling weak demand. These are the nights a property most needs help filling, and the best place to aim promotions and ad spend.

Which soft dates are coming up in the next six weeks? That's where we should aim the next campaign.

3 · Distribution and OTA economics

Airbnb host-only vs split service fee

How Airbnb charges its service fee: the older split fee shares it between host and guest, and the host-only (single) fee puts all of it on the host. Airbnb is moving all hosts to the single fee.

Has Airbnb moved you to the single host-only fee yet? It changes the price guests see and what you keep.

Booking.com Genius

Booking.com's guest-loyalty programme; a property opts in by offering Genius members a discount in exchange for more visibility.

Booking.com Genius gets you more visibility, but it costs you a discount on every booking it brings.

Channel mix

The split of bookings across channels — direct, each OTA, phone, walk-in — and the clearest read on OTA dependence.

$\text{Bookings by channel} \div \text{Total bookings}$

What does your channel mix look like? If most bookings come through OTAs, direct is the big opportunity.

CRS (central reservation system)

The rate and inventory brain above the PMS, mostly at multi-property operations.

With several properties, a CRS keeps rates and availability in step across all of them.

4 · Demand, segments and time

Changeover day

The fixed day a multi-night property turns over, common at cabins and glamping sites, which shapes what can be sold at all.

If Saturday is your changeover day, we should sell weeks that start on Saturday.

Date classes

Peak, shoulder and low, weekend and midweek — every pacing conversation happens per class, not per month.

Let's talk about pace by date class — peak weekends and quiet midweeks tell very different stories.

Search vs discovery demand

Harvesting someone already looking versus creating the want; HGM's whole reason for existing.

Search catches people already looking for a place like yours; discovery makes people want it before they knew it existed.

Drive market vs fly market

Whether guests arrive by car or plane; it sets lead time, radius and creative.

Are you mainly a drive market? If most guests come by car, we can target nearby cities and book closer in.

Shoulder season

The stretch between peak and low, where marketing pushes matter most.

The shoulder season is where marketing earns its keep — peak sells itself.

Feeder market

The cities guests actually come from — the targeting question in an owner's words.

Where do most of your guests come from? That's your feeder market, and it's where we focus the ads.

Slow season

The owner's word for low season, and one of the ICP's stated pain points.

What does the slow season look like for you, and what have you tried to fill it?

Midweek gap

The structural soft spot at nearly every property in this ICP.

Most properties like yours have a midweek gap — what would bring guests in on a Tuesday?

5 · Property types, structure and ownership

Flag

The chain brand a property operates under; to be flagged is to carry one.

Would you ever consider a flag, or is staying independent part of who you are?

OTB (on the books)

Rooms and revenue already reserved for a future date, before any further pickup.

What do you have on the books for the holidays so far?

Franchise

Paying a chain for its brand, systems and reservation flow while still owning and running the property.

A franchise brings you a chain's booking system, but you pay fees and give up some control.

Pickup

New reservations added in a period for a future date; the velocity read.

OTB today - OTB at the last reading

How much pickup did you see last week? A jump tells us the campaign is working.

Keys, rooms and units

The three words for the same inventory; owners say keys, the doctrine says units.

How many keys do you have? Cabins and suites all count, so we know how much there is to sell.

Room type

A sellable category of room or unit, each with its own rate and availability.

Which room type sells out first? That's usually where there's room to raise the rate.

Review score

The rating on Google, Tripadvisor and each OTA, which feeds ranking and rate power.

Your review score affects where you rank on every OTA, so it's worth protecting.

Who you are talking to

Owner, general manager, revenue manager, asset manager — four seats, four scorecards.

Before the call, it helps to know who we're talking to — the owner cares about different numbers than a general manager.

7 · Marketing metrics and HGM's translation

Attribution window

How long after seeing or clicking an ad a booking still counts.

With a seven-day attribution window, a guest who clicks on Monday and books on Friday still counts.

6 · Guest behaviour and reputation

Cancellation rate

The share of bookings cancelled before arrival; markedly higher on OTA bookings.

$\text{Cancelled bookings} \div \text{Total bookings}$

Your cancellation rate is higher on OTA bookings — another reason to win more of them direct.

Blended CPB

Total ad spend divided by every attributed booking — the average cost of a booking.

$\text{Total ad spend} \div \text{All attributed bookings}$

Your blended CPB is the average cost of every booking the ads brought in.

Guest lifetime value

Total value of a guest across every stay rather than one booking.

A guest who comes back every year is worth far more than one booking — that's their lifetime value.

Click vs view-through

Whether the booking followed someone clicking the ad, or merely seeing it.

Some of those bookings were view-through — people saw the ad but didn't click — so we count them carefully.

Pre-arrival sequence

The window where upsell and expectation-setting actually work.

The pre-arrival sequence is the best moment to offer a spa booking or a dinner reservation.

CPA (cost per acquisition)

What a defined conversion costs; CPB is the hospitality-specific case. $\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Conversions}$

CPA is what we pay for each result we asked for — a lead, a sign-up, a booking.

Repeat rate

The share of guests who come back — the cheapest demand a property has.

$\text{Returning guests} \div \text{Total guests}$

What's your repeat rate? Returning guests are the cheapest bookings you'll ever get.

CPB (cost per booking)

Ad spend divided by attributed bookings; effective commission is the honest version of it.

$\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Attributed bookings}$

Your CPB tells you what each ad-driven booking cost, which we can compare against OTA commission.

Creative fatigue index

The doctrine's composite for when creative is worn out.

The creative fatigue index is telling us this video has run its course — time for fresh footage.

Deliverability

Whether email reaches the inbox at all.

If deliverability is poor, the newsletter is landing in spam and nobody sees the offer.

Email click rate

The share of delivered emails where someone clicked through — the honest engagement read.

$\text{Clicks} \div \text{Delivered emails}$

Opens are noisy these days, so the email click rate is the number we trust.

Email open rate

The share of delivered emails opened; increasingly noisy since mail privacy protections.

Your email open rate looks high, but privacy settings inflate it, so we watch clicks too.

Frequency

How many times the average person saw it; the fatigue diagnostic. $\text{Impressions} \div \text{Reach}$

Frequency is climbing, so the same people are seeing the ad too often — time to refresh it.

Hold rate

The share of people who keep watching past the hook to a ThruPlay (the whole video, or at least 15 seconds); hooking without holding is a thumbnail, not a creative.

$\text{ThruPlays} \div \text{3-second video plays}$

The hold rate shows people watch to the end, so the story is working, not just the first shot.

Hook rate

The share of impressions where someone watched at least the first three seconds of a video.

$\text{3-second video plays} \div \text{Impressions}$

The hook rate on the sunrise clip is strong — people stop scrolling in the first few seconds.

Impressions

The number of times an ad was shown, counting repeats to the same person.

Impressions count every time the ad was shown, including repeats to the same person.

Incremental CPB

What a booking costs counting only the ones that would not have happened anyway.

$\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Bookings that wouldn't have happened without the ads}$

Incremental CPB counts only the bookings the ads truly created, so it's usually higher than the average.

Landing-page conversion rate

The share of visitors who take the page's action.

$\text{Conversions} \div \text{Sessions}$

Traffic is good, but the landing-page conversion rate is low, so the page is where we'll focus next.

Pixel

The browser-side tag that reports site events back to the ad platform.

Is the pixel firing on your booking engine? Without it, we can't see which ads lead to bookings.

Reach

The number of distinct people an ad was shown to.

Reach tells us how many different people saw the ad, not how many times it was shown.

Retargeting vs prospecting

Harvesting a warm pool versus building a new one.

Retargeting reminds people who already visited, while prospecting finds new guests — we need both.

ROAS (return on ad spend)

Attributed revenue divided by ad spend; always name whether you mean pixel or blended.

$\text{Attributed revenue} \div \text{Ad spend}$

Your ROAS looks strong, but is that the pixel number or blended? They tell different stories.

8 · Tools and software, by category

OTAs and niche marketplaces

Booking.com, Expedia, Airbnb, Vrbo, plus Hipcamp, Glamping Hub, Mr & Mrs Smith.

Which OTAs and niche marketplaces are you listed on — just the big ones, or glamping sites too?

9 · The owner-operator mindset

Opportunity cost

The value of the best option you gave up by choosing another. In hospitality, it's usually the revenue a room, date or budget could have earned if it had been used differently.

Holding that weekend for a possible wedding has an opportunity cost — the guests you turn away in the meantime.

Not taught and not on the check. Here for when you meet a word on a call or in a report.

1 • Core revenue metrics

Attrition The contract clause that makes a group pay for rooms it blocked but didn't fill.

If the wedding group releases rooms late, does your contract have an attrition clause to cover it?

Budget vs forecast A budget sets the targets the organisation intends to hit; a forecast predicts what is likely to happen from live performance and current data.

Is that number from your budget or your latest forecast? I want to know whether we're chasing the plan or reality.

Event and wedding revenue Group and event income, which at wineries and lodges can rival rooms.

How much of your year is event and wedding revenue? For some lodges it's as big as the rooms side.

Fixed vs variable cost Why an empty midweek room costs little to fill and a discounted one still hurts.

Most of your costs are fixed, so filling an empty midweek room costs you very little.

Flash report A one-page summary of yesterday's rooms, revenue and rate, produced first thing each morning.

Could we see the flash report on a Monday? It's the quickest way to spot a soft week early.

Folio A guest's running bill for the stay — room charges plus everything they add to it.

If we track what's on each guest's folio, we'll see which add-ons actually sell.

GOP (gross operating profit) What is left after departmental and undistributed costs — the operator's profit line.

$$\text{GOP} = \text{Revenue} - \text{departmental} - \text{undistributed costs}$$

GOP is your operating profit before the owner's fixed costs — it's where good management shows up.

GOPPAR (gross operating profit per available room) Gross operating profit per available room — profitability rather than topline.

$$\text{GOPPAR} = \text{GOP} \div \text{Rooms available}$$

GOPPAR tells us whether the extra bookings made money, not just revenue.

MPI (market penetration index) Your share of the comp set's occupancy; above 100 means you are filling better than the set.

$$\text{MPI} = (\text{Your occupancy} \div \text{Comp set occupancy}) \times 100$$

Your MPI says you're filling better than the comp set — so it may be time to test a higher rate.

Night audit The overnight close-out that locks in the day's room charges and rolls the property into the next date.

Once the night audit runs, yesterday's numbers are locked, so that's when your report is reliable.

Rooms profit margin What the rooms department keeps after its own costs.

$$\text{Rooms profit} \div \text{Rooms revenue}$$

Your rooms profit margin is healthy, which gives us room to spend a little to win direct bookings.

Total revenue vs rooms revenue Which one an owner means when they say revenue — worth establishing early on a call.

When you say revenue is up, do you mean total revenue or just rooms?

USALI (Uniform System of Accounts for the Lodging Industry)

The uniform accounting standard that fixes what goes on which line of a hotel P&L.

Your accountant probably follows USALI, so their P&L lines should match what other resorts report.

Yield management Moving price and availability in response to real-time demand, to maximise revenue rather than just fill rooms; it started in the airline industry and was adopted into hospitality.

Yield management is really about selling the right night to the right guest at the right price, not just filling rooms.

2 • Rates, pricing and restrictions

Add-on / enhancement An extra bought at or after booking — firewood, breakfast, a late checkout.

Firewood and late checkout are easy add-ons — have you tried offering them at booking?

Advance purchase window How far ahead of arrival a cheaper non-refundable rate is still available.

How far out does your advance purchase rate stay open? A shorter window protects your late bookings.

BAR (best available rate) A date's standard public rate, before any fenced discount or package is applied.

What's your BAR for that weekend? I'd like to know the starting point before any offer.

Best-rate guarantee The promise the direct site won't be beaten, and the mechanics behind it.

A best-rate guarantee on your site tells guests they don't need to shop around.

Blackout dates Dates an offer or discounted rate explicitly does not apply to.

Should the promo have blackout dates over the long weekend? You'll sell those nights anyway.

Cancellation policy The deadline and penalty structure behind the cancellation rate.

Your cancellation policy is generous — that's good for guests, but it may explain some late cancellations.

Deposit policy When money is taken, and how much.

What's your deposit policy? A deposit up front tends to cut down on no-shows.

Displacement Taking a group at a lower rate and losing higher-rate individual bookings you would otherwise have had on those dates.

Before you take the group at a lower rate, let's check the displacement — you might lose better-paying guests.

Last-minute rate A discount released close to arrival to clear unsold inventory.

A last-minute rate can fill empty rooms, but if you use it too often guests learn to wait.

Length-of-stay pricing Pricing by the number of nights booked rather than by date.

Would length-of-stay pricing help? A lower nightly rate for three nights could stretch short stays.

Minimum length of stay (min LOS) A rule that a date can only be booked as part of a stay of at least so many nights.

A two-night minimum on summer weekends protects you from single-night gaps.

Non-refundable / advance purchase Pay now, no refund, lower rate — the main tool against cancellation risk.

A non-refundable rate gives price-sensitive guests a deal and gives you certainty.

Promo code A code unlocking a fenced offer.

If we give each campaign its own promo code, we'll know exactly which bookings it brought in.

Upsell Selling an extra alongside the stay — breakfast, a late checkout, firewood.

What's the easiest upsell to offer — breakfast, a late checkout, a bottle of wine in the room?

Yield calendar The month-at-a-glance view an owner works from, with each date coloured by how well it is selling.

Could you share your yield calendar? It shows us at a glance which dates need help.

3 · Distribution and OTA economics

Allotment A block of rooms held under contract for one channel or buyer to sell.

Do you give a tour operator an allotment of rooms? We should know which rooms aren't yours to sell.

Billboard effect The contested claim that being listed on an OTA drives extra direct bookings by putting the property in front of more people.

Some owners stay on the OTAs for the billboard effect — the hope that guests find them there and then book direct.

Book-direct incentive What the direct channel offers that an OTA can't match without breaking parity.

A book-direct incentive like free breakfast gives guests a reason to skip the OTA without breaking parity.

Channel conflict Two channels selling the same room at prices that undercut each other.

If your own site shows a higher price than Expedia, that channel conflict sends guests straight to the OTA.

Commission vs markup Two ways a channel takes its cut, with different effects on the rate a guest sees.

Is that OTA taking a commission or adding a markup? It changes what the guest actually pays.

Direct booking share The share of bookings taken on the property's own site; what HGM's guarantee is measured in.

$\text{Direct bookings} \div \text{Total bookings}$

Our goal is to grow your direct booking share, so more of each booking stays with you.

Direct-booking widget See *Price comparison widget*.

Distribution cost Everything paid to get the booking: commission, fees, processing.

$\text{Commission} + \text{channel fees} + \text{payment processing}$

When we add up commission, fees and card processing, your distribution cost is the real price of each booking.

Expedia TravelAds Expedia's pay-per-click sponsored listings inside Expedia search (TravelAds Sponsored Listings); the guest still books on Expedia.

Have you tried Expedia TravelAds? It's paid placement inside Expedia, so the guest still books there.

Google free booking links Unpaid rate listings in Google's hotel results.

Your free booking links on Google let guests book direct from the search results without paying for the click.

Google Hotel Ads Paid placement in Google's hotel results, bought by the click or with goal-based bidding; Google retired its commission options in 2024.

Google Hotel Ads put your direct rate right beside the OTAs when someone searches for you.

OTA (online travel agency) A third-party marketplace selling the room for a cut.

The OTAs are good for being found, but every booking there costs you commission.

Preferred Partner Booking.com programme where eligible properties pay a slightly higher commission for better placement and a badge.

Preferred Partner moves you up the Booking.com results, but you pay more commission for it.

Price comparison widget An overlay on the property's own site that compares its price to the OTAs and nudges the guest to book direct; also called a direct-booking widget. A price comparison widget on your site shows guests they won't find a better rate on the OTAs.

4 · Demand, segments and time

Compression When demand across a whole market spikes and every property can hold or raise its rate.

When the big festival is in town, there's compression across the whole area, so you can hold your rate.

Demand calendar The dated list of what will move demand in the market.

Let's build a demand calendar of local events so we're never surprised by a busy weekend.

Need dates The dates that need help, as opposed to the ones that sell themselves.

Which are your need dates this quarter? Those are the ones worth spending on.

Seasonality The property's yearly demand shape, which sets when rate can be pushed and when marketing has to work.

Your seasonality tells us when to push rate and when marketing has to do the heavy lifting.

T-minus checkpoints T-90, T-60, T-30, T-14, T-7 — where the doctrine takes pace readings.

We check pace at set points before arrival, so a soft date is caught while there's still time to act.

5 · Property types, structure and ownership

All-inclusive A rate covering stay, meals and most on-property spend.

With an all-inclusive rate, the value story is about what guests don't have to think about.

Buyout Selling the entire property to one group for a date range.

A full buyout for a retreat can fill a slow week in one booking.

Eco-resort A property whose environmental design is part of the product.

As an eco-resort, your sustainability story is part of the product, so it belongs in the ads.

Housekeeping turnover The cost and time of cleaning and resetting a unit between guests, which sets how short a stay can profitably be.

If housekeeping turnover takes most of a day, one-night stays may cost more than they earn.

Independent hotel Unbranded and self-distributed, which is this ICP by default.

As an independent hotel, you don't have a chain's booking system behind you, so every direct booking is yours to win.

Inventory The rooms or units available to sell on a date, across every channel.

How much inventory do you have left for New Year's across all channels?

Lodge A full-service rural property where the setting and the activities are the product.

At a lodge like yours, the setting and the activities are what people are really booking.

Management company vs owner-operator Whether a third party runs the property or the founder does.

Is the property run by a management company, or do you operate it yourself?

Micro-resort HGM's term for a small, high-design, multi-unit property.

A micro-resort sells an experience a big hotel can't, so we lead with the design and the setting.

REIT (real estate investment trust) A listed property-owning trust; the far end of the ownership spectrum from this ICP.

A REIT owns hotels as investments — very different from an owner who built the place themselves.

Retreat A hosted multi-day programme using the property; a distinct demand source.

Yoga and corporate retreats can fill a whole week in the shoulder season.

Sale multiple A property's price expressed as a multiple of its earnings — the other way a sale gets talked about, alongside cap rate.

Buyers might talk about your sale multiple rather than a cap rate, but it's the same question — what is this place worth?

Soft brand / affiliation Keeping your own name while joining a collection for distribution and marketing.

A soft brand lets you keep your own name while getting the reach of a larger collection.

Wellness resort A property built around spa, movement or restorative programming.

For a wellness resort, the programming is the reason to book, so it should lead every campaign.

6 · Guest behaviour and reputation

ALOS (average length of stay) The average nights per booking across a period; it moves cleaning cost and orphan nights.

$\text{Room nights} \div \text{Bookings}$

If we can nudge your ALOS up from two nights to three, housekeeping and orphan nights both get easier.

Guest journey stages Dream, plan, book, stay, share — the frame most hospitality content sits on.

We plan content around the guest journey — dreaming, planning, booking, staying and sharing.

Guest profile The stored record of a returning guest — past stays, preferences, spend — that lets staff treat them as known.

If the guest profile remembers their favourite cabin, you can offer it before they ask.

Look-to-book The share of visitors or searches that complete a booking.

$\text{Bookings} \div \text{Site visits}$

Lots of people visit your booking page, but the look-to-book is low — something is stopping them.

LOS (length of stay) The number of nights in a single booking.

Longer LOS usually means fewer turnovers and happier housekeeping.

Loyalty programme Repeat-driving mechanics an independent can run without a chain scheme.

You don't need a chain's points scheme — a simple loyalty programme for returning guests can work just as well.

Post-stay sequence Review requests, rebooking and the start of the repeat cycle.

The post-stay sequence is where we ask for the review and plant the idea of coming back.

Referral programme Guests bringing guests, and how the incentive is fenced.

A referral programme turns happy guests into your best marketing.

Walk-in A guest booking at the desk, with no channel cost at all.

A walk-in costs you nothing in commission, so it's worth knowing how many you get.

7 · Marketing metrics and HGM's translation

Accepted secondary hosts Domains allowed to fire a client's pixel besides their main site — GHL subdomains, PMS booking engines, Wix static hosts, Netlify staging.
The booking engine's domain is an accepted secondary host, so events from it aren't a problem.

Ad (Meta) The bottom level of Meta's structure — the creative and copy people actually see.

Each ad is what the guest actually sees — the image, the words and the button.

Ad account A single billing entity in Meta with its own campaigns, ID and spend history.

Which ad account is this campaign running in? We always match on the account ID.

Ad set The middle level of Meta's structure, where audience, placements, schedule and, without CBO, budget are set.

Let's split the audiences into separate ad sets so we can see which one books better.

Advantage+ audience Meta's automated targeting, where your audience inputs act as suggestions rather than limits.
With Advantage+ audience, Meta treats our targeting as a suggestion and looks wider.

Advantage+ creative Meta's automatic enhancements to an ad's assets, such as cropping, brightness and text variations.

Advantage+ creative adjusted the crop and brightness automatically, so check the ad looks right.

Aggregated Event Measurement (AEM) Meta's privacy-preserving method for measuring web conversions from people who opted out of tracking on iPhone; reported results can be modelled, limited or delayed.

Because of Aggregated Event Measurement, some iPhone bookings show up late or not at all in Meta.

Amount spent What an account actually spent in a period, as distinct from the budget it was set to.

The amount spent this week is lower than the budget, so the campaign may not be delivering.

Audience segments Signals about existing and engaged customers you give Meta inside Advantage+ sales campaigns (formerly Advantage+ shopping).

We've added past guests as an audience segment so Meta knows who's already a customer.

Average direct booking value The average value of one direct booking.

$\text{Direct booking revenue} \div \text{Direct bookings}$

Your average direct booking value is higher than on the OTAs, which makes every direct booking worth more.

Basic vs Advanced setup The Meta Ads column in HGM's CRM sheet, recording whether a client has a Basic or an Advanced Meta setup.

Check the CRM sheet — is this client on a Basic or an Advanced Meta setup?

Blended ROAS Booking revenue from the property's own records divided by total Meta spend; it runs lower than pixel ROAS, so always say which you mean.

$\text{Booking revenue} \div \text{Total Meta spend}$

Blended ROAS uses the property's real booking revenue, so it usually runs lower than what Meta reports.

Boosted post An Instagram or Facebook post promoted straight from the app or Page; it also appears in Ads Manager as a campaign, with fewer targeting options than an ad built there.

That boosted post is still showing as active after its end date — check it isn't still spending.

Broad targeting Targeting with minimal constraints, leaving Meta to find the people most likely to act.

Broad targeting leaves the audience to Meta, so we test it against narrower audiences before leaning on it.

Business Manager (BM) Meta's container that owns a business's ad accounts, pages, pixels and user access; clients share their pixels into HGM's Business Manager.

Has the client shared their pixel into our Business Manager yet?

Campaign (Meta) The top level of Meta's three-level structure, where the objective and, under CBO, the budget are set.

Set the objective at the campaign level first — everything below it follows from that.

CBO (Advantage+ campaign budget) A budget set once at campaign level and spread across ad sets by Meta; without it, each ad set holds its own budget.

With CBO on, the budget sits at the campaign level, so the ad sets will show zero on their own.

Cost per link click What a click through to the site costs, as distinct from CPC, which counts any click.

$\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Link clicks}$

Cost per link click is what we pay for someone actually reaching the website.

Cost per Meta-attributed booking What each Meta-attributed booking cost.

$\text{Meta spend} \div \text{Meta-attributed bookings}$

Cost per Meta-attributed booking counts only bookings we can trace to Meta through a code or link.

Cost per result What each counted result cost.

$\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Results}$

Cost per result depends on the objective — a lead campaign's result isn't a booking.

CPC (cost per click) What a click costs.

$\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Clicks}$

CPC counts any click on the ad, including likes and profile taps, so it can look cheaper than it is.

CPL (cost per lead) What a lead costs; at HGM, Meta spend divided by Meta Lead events, which are usually an email sign-up.

$\text{Ad spend} \div \text{Leads (Meta Lead events)}$

Your CPL tells us what each new lead costs before they've booked anything.

Creative The image or video at the centre of an ad.

The creative is the first thing people notice, so it has to show the stay, not just the room.

CTA (call to action) The button or line that tells someone what to do next, such as Book now.

Let's change the CTA from Learn more to Book now and see if more people click through.

CTR (click-through rate) Clicks divided by impressions.

$\text{Clicks} \div \text{Impressions}$

CTR is the share of people who clicked after seeing the ad.

Custom audience People drawn from your own data — site visitors, engagers or a customer list.

We built a custom audience from your past guests so we can invite them back.

Custom conversion A rule that turns a URL or event detail into a conversion Meta can count and optimise for.

We set up a custom conversion for the thank-you page so completed bookings get counted.

Daily vs lifetime budget Spend capped per day versus a fixed total spread across the schedule.

Is this on a daily or lifetime budget? It changes how we read the spend.

Dark account A client account marked Not Live or Paused that is still spending — the most important catch in HGM's ad spend check.

This account is paused in our records but still spending — that's a dark account.

Dataset Meta's current name for a pixel together with its server connection and any other event sources; see Pixel.

Meta now calls it a dataset, but it's the same pixel plus its server connection.

Decision Making table The section of HGM's Benchmarks doc that is the only source of a campaign's state.

The Decision Making table sets a campaign's state, so check it before calling one weak.

Delivery status Whether a campaign is active or paused, and whether an active one is actually serving — it can be active and still not deliver, for example past its stop time or stuck in learning limited.

The delivery status says active, but nothing's spending — let's check whether it's stuck in learning.

Diagnostics The metrics that explain a campaign's state but never set it — CPC, CPM, CTR, frequency and cost per booking.

Frequency and CPM are diagnostics — they explain why a campaign is struggling, but they don't decide its state.

Diff status (New, Still open, Fixed) How HGM's weekly reports mark each issue against the week before, with the weeks it has been open counted.

That issue has been still open for three weeks, so it needs an owner.

Direct booking revenue Revenue from direct bookings as recorded in the property's PMS.

Direct booking revenue comes from the PMS, not from Meta, so it's the owner's real number.

Documented vs live budget The budget recorded in HGM's Master Meta Ads sheet against what the ad account is actually running.

The documented budget and the live budget don't match — the account is spending more than agreed.

Dynamic creative Meta combining the images, video and text you supply into variations and serving the best performers; since 2026 this is largely handled inside Advantage+ creative.

Dynamic creative is mixing our headlines and images to find the best combination.

EMQ (event match quality) Meta's score, out of 10, for how well the customer details sent with an event match to real Meta users.

The EMQ score is low, so Meta can't match many of these bookings to real people — worth fixing.

Funnel stages (ToF, MoF, BoF) Top, middle and bottom of funnel — building awareness, warming interest, then converting; HGM campaign names carry the prefix.

This is a ToF campaign, so judge it on reach, not bookings.

Geo targeting Aiming ads by location — a country, listed cities, or a radius around a point.

Let's tighten the geo targeting to cities within a three-hour drive.

GHL funnel (GoHighLevel funnel) A landing page built in GoHighLevel, HGM's landing-page and CRM tool, whose sub-account tracking settings carry the pixel ID.

The GHL funnel was cloned from another client, so check it isn't carrying their pixel.

Governing metric The one metric that sets a campaign's state in HGM's reports — CPL for Lead Gen, ROAS for Sales.

For a Lead Gen campaign, CPL is the governing metric — the others just help explain it.

Headline The short bold line that sits below an ad's creative.

Keep the headline short and specific — it's what people read after the image.

IG Discovery and Keyword campaigns HGM's top-of-funnel Instagram campaigns, reported as a spend line only and not scored.

The IG Discovery campaigns are for awareness, so we report their spend but don't score them.

iOS 14 signal loss The drop in tracking data after Apple's App Tracking Transparency prompt (iOS 14.5, April 2021), and the reason pixel numbers undercount and need cross-checking against booking data.

Because of iOS signal loss, the pixel undercounts bookings, so we always check against the booking data.

Lead Gen campaign HGM's middle-of-funnel campaign type on the leads objective, usually retargeting engagers, scored on CPL over 30 days.

The Lead Gen campaign is warming up past engagers, so we judge it on cost per lead.

Learning phase The period after a launch or significant edit when Meta is still working out delivery and results are unstable; it usually needs about 50 optimisation events in the 7 days after launch or the edit to exit.

The campaign is still in its learning phase, so give it a few days before making changes.

Link CTR The share of impressions that became a click through to the site; the all-clicks CTR also counts likes, expands and profile taps.

$\text{Link CTR} = \frac{\text{Link clicks}}{\text{Impressions}} \times 100$

Link CTR only counts clicks to the website, so it's the better measure of real interest.

Link-in-bio The link in a social profile, used as a route to attribute bookings without the pixel.

We track bookings from the link-in-bio separately, because the pixel doesn't always see them.

Lookalike audience People Meta judges similar to a seed audience you supply.

A lookalike audience built from past guests helps us find new people like them.

Marginal CPB What the next booking costs at the current spend level, rather than the average.

$\text{Marginal CPB} = \frac{\text{Extra spend}}{\text{Extra bookings it brought}}$

Adding more budget raises the marginal CPB — the next booking costs more than the last one.

MCP-disabled account An ad account the Meta connector can't read, so the weekly Ads Manager export is used instead.

This is an MCP-disabled account, so we'll use the weekly Ads Manager export instead.

Meta Ads Library Meta's public, searchable archive of every active ad, useful for checking what competitors are running.

Let's check the Meta Ads Library to see what other resorts nearby are running.

Meta-attributed bookings Bookings tied to Meta through link-in-bio, a promo code or a UTM rather than the pixel. These Meta-attributed bookings came through promo codes, not the pixel.

MoF lookalike sales campaign A sales-objective campaign aimed at lookalikes, with no band of its own, scored on the retargeting ROAS bands. The MoF lookalike sales campaign is scored against the retargeting ROAS bands.

New vs total leads First-time leads against every Lead event, including leads from Instagram tags. Total leads look high, but new leads are flat — most are people we already had.

Objective The outcome Meta optimises delivery for, such as leads, sales, awareness or engagement. The objective tells Meta what to optimise for, so pick sales if bookings are the goal.

Percent of booking value Meta spend as a share of booking revenue.

$$\text{Meta spend} \div \text{Booking revenue} \times 100$$

Meta spend as a percent of booking value lets the owner compare ad cost with what an OTA would take.

Pixel cross-contamination Another client's domain firing events into a pixel, usually from a cloned GHL funnel still carrying the old pixel ID.

We found pixel cross-contamination — another client's site is firing into this pixel.

Pixel ROAS ROAS as Meta's pixel reports it, from the revenue Meta attributes to ads.

$$\text{Purchase conversion value} \div \text{Ad spend}$$

Pixel ROAS is what Meta reports, so we always say which ROAS we mean.

Placements Where an ad appears — Feed, Stories, Reels, Audience Network; Advantage+ placements lets Meta choose.

Reels placements are doing well for this property, so let's give them more of the budget.

Primary text (ad copy) The main body text that sits above an ad's creative.

The primary text should say why this stay is different in the first line.

Purchase conversion value The booking revenue Meta attributes to an ad through purchase events.

Purchase conversion value is the booking revenue Meta credits to the ads.

Results The count of whatever outcome the campaign's objective is set to, such as leads or purchases.

In Ads Manager, results means whatever the objective counts — leads here, not bookings.

Sales / Retargeting campaign HGM's bottom-of-funnel campaign type on the sales objective, retargeting site visitors, scored on ROAS over 14 days.

The Sales / Retargeting campaign shows ads to people who've already visited the website, so we judge it on ROAS.

Scoring window The lookback period HGM scores each campaign type over; accounts read from a CSV fallback use a 21-day provisional window.

This account is on the CSV fallback, so it's using a shorter scoring window for now.

Sending host The domain a pixel's events come from, checked against the domains expected for that client. Check the sending host — events should only come from the client's own domains.

Server events vs browser events The two routes events reach Meta — the browser through the pixel, the server through CAPI — matched by a shared event ID so one booking isn't counted twice.

We're getting browser events but no server events, which means CAPI isn't connected yet.

Silent pixel A pixel sending zero or very few events for a client who is live.

That client is live but the pixel is silent — something is broken on the site.

Spend gate The minimum spend a campaign needs in its window before HGM scores it; below it, its state reads Under gate.

The campaign hasn't cleared the spend gate yet, so don't read too much into its numbers.

Spend-check flags (Match, Warning, Critical, Blocker) The four flags HGM's ad spend check raises, set by the gap between documented and live budget and by any spend on accounts marked Not Live or Paused.

The spend check raised a Critical flag on this account, so it needs a look.

Split or duplicate pixels One client running two live pixels, so the funnel is either divided between them or counted twice.

This client has split pixels, so half the funnel is reporting to the wrong place.

Standard events Meta's predefined names for site actions — PageView, ViewContent, Lead, InitiateCheckout, Purchase and so on.

Make sure the Purchase standard event fires on the confirmation page, not the checkout page.

8 · Tools and software, by category

Accounting systems Where the P&L is actually assembled. Your accounting system is where the real P&L lives, so that's where the final numbers come from.

Activity booking systems Scheduling and payment for tours, rentals and on-property experiences.

If guests book tours through an activity booking system, we can promote those experiences too.

Ads Manager export The weekly CSV of campaign and ad set spend, budgets, purchases and leads, used where the connector can't read an account.

Pull the Ads Manager export for that account, since the connector can't read it.

Benchmarking tools Comp-set performance reporting; STR (part of CoStar) for hotels, KeyData for vacation and short-term rentals.

A benchmarking tool would show how you compare with similar properties nearby.

Benchmarks doc HGM's Google Doc of campaign benchmarks, holding the Decision Making table.

The Benchmarks doc sets what good looks like for each campaign type.

Campground and glamping systems Newbook, Campspot — the world a glamping client's stack usually comes from. Glamping clients often run on campground systems, which work differently from hotel software.

Client Performance Tracking sheet HGM's Google Sheet of client booking revenue, the source for blended ROAS.

Blended ROAS comes from the Client Performance Tracking sheet, not from Meta.

CRM sheet HGM's Google Sheet of client records, including whether each has a Basic or Advanced Meta setup.

Check the CRM sheet to see whether this client has a Basic or Advanced setup.

Direct-booking conversion tools Price comparison and nudges on the property's own site; Triptease, The Hotels Network.

A direct-booking conversion tool shows guests they're getting the best price on your own site.

HG AI (Hidden Gem AI) The tool a campaign is handed to when it reaches a Review or Scale state.

Once a campaign reaches Review, it's handed to HG AI for a closer look.

HGM's own stack GoHighLevel, ManyChat, Meta pixel and CAPI — what HGM connects into the above.

Our own stack is what plugs into your booking tools, so it helps to know which pieces we use.

Master Meta Ads sheet HGM's Google Sheet recording each client's documented Meta budget and status.

The Master Meta Ads sheet holds the agreed budget, so that's what we check the live spend against.

Meta connector (MCP) The claude.ai connection that reads Meta ad accounts, campaigns and datasets live.

The Meta connector reads the ad accounts live, so the weekly check is up to date.

Notes by Gemini The auto-generated meeting notes attached to HGM's Strategy and Sync calendar events. The action items are in the Notes by Gemini from Tuesday's sync.

Payments Card capture and processing inside the PMS.

If payments are handled inside your PMS, deposits can be taken the moment someone books.

Reputation tools Review aggregation and response; Revinate, TrustYou.

A reputation tool pulls all your reviews into one place so nothing goes unanswered.

Spa booking systems Scheduling and payment for treatments; Book4Time, Mindbody.

If spa treatments can be booked online, we can promote them in the pre-arrival email.

9 · The owner-operator mindset

Asset manager vs founder-operator The mindset HGM's ICP is defined against.

You're not an asset manager looking at a spreadsheet — you built this place, and that changes how we talk about it.

Exit vocabulary NOI multiple, resort equity value, portfolio expansion — why NOI matters emotionally.

Even if you never sell, knowing the exit vocabulary helps you see why growing NOI matters.

Owner-operator founder Someone whose dream was to build this stay, who cares about the place and not just the spreadsheet.

As an owner-operator founder, you care about the place as much as the numbers, and our marketing should reflect that.

GOES WITH

Owners

Nicole Araya and Kyle Zinger

The HGM Client Tech Stack Guide puts vendor names to the tools in section 8. To look a word up mid-call, keep this PDF open and use Find (Ctrl+F or Cmd+F).